2.4 Preliminary Preparation

Preliminary preparation of food is very essential to prepare healthy delicious dishes. The efficiency of a cook depends on how he/she organizes work in the kitchen. If pre-preparation is thoroughly and systematically done then the service will be carried out smoothly.

A good chef takes pride in the thoroughness and quality of the pre-preparation or mise-en-place (pronounced meez-on-plahss). This French term meaning "everything put in place," has become almost a professional password in kitchen, because it is important for the success of the establishment.

Pre-preparation saves time and energy. The following steps should be followed before the actual cooking.

- Assemble tools required.
- Collect ingredients needed for cooking
- Wash, trim, cut, prepare, and measure raw materials.
- Check equipment before cooking.

a. Cleaning/Washing: All raw ingredients should be washed and cleaned before cooking to ensure microbiological safety of food. All vegetables should be washed thoroughly before peeling or cutting.



Dry ingredients like cereals and pulses should be cleaned to remove dirt, stones and foreign matter before cooking.

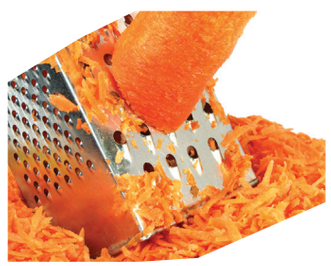
b. Peeling: Most of the vegetables and fruits are peeled before the preparation of recipe. The outer skin will be peeled using a peeler or knife. Care should be taken to peel the skin very thin because most of the nutrients are under the skin of the fruits and vegetables. Certain vegetables like potatoes can also be peeled after boiling. Tomato skin can be peeled after blanching.



c. Grinding: Grinding reduces the food to a fine form. Dry grinding helps to get masala powders and wet grinding helps to get chutneys and batters for idli, dosai and adai.



d. Grating: Shredding of certain foodstuffs is called grating. Vegetables and fruits can be grated to make salads interesting. Cheese can be shredded to decorate the foods prepared.



e. Soaking: Foodstuffs are generally soaked to make them soft as it helps to make cooking faster and grinding easier. Cereals and pulses are soaked for grinding and cooking. It enhances



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